

Image Of God

doc-image-of-god
Anthropology · Imago Dei · doctrine · unanimous_lineages

AFFIRMS

Supported across the whole Bible
Subject named directly in
Scripture
No NT manuscript apparatus
applies

Statement under examination

All human beings are created in the image of God (imago Dei), bearing inherent dignity, moral agency, rationality, and capacity for relationship with God, irrespective of age, ability, ethnicity, or stage of development.

In plain language

Genesis 1:26-27 says God made humanity ('adam' in Hebrew) in his image ('tselem') and according to his likeness ('demuth'), and applies this to male and female together. Both nouns carry the ending 'our', so the text reads in our image, after our likeness. The same word for image ('tselem') grounds the murder prohibition in Genesis 9:6, where the causal 'because in the image of God he made humanity' shows the image survives the fall and belongs to every person whose life is protected. Psalm 8 restates the dignity in royal language, and James 3:9 says humans have been made according to the likeness ('homoiosis' in Greek) of God, using a perfect-tense verb (a completed action whose result still stands, 'gegonotas', meaning 'having been made') that marks this as a settled, enduring condition of every person, then forbids cursing them on that basis. Colossians 3:10 speaks of being renewed in knowledge ('epignosis') according to the image ('eikon') of the Creator, echoing Genesis. Across Law, Writings, and apostolic letters the same vocabulary keeps saying the image is true of humanity as such, with no limit by age, ability, ethnicity, or stage of development. So the proposition that all humans bear God's image is strongly supported. Where readers diverge is not whether humans bear the image but what the image consists of. The Hebrew word for image ('tselem') most often names a physical representation or statue, the word for likeness ('demuth') means resemblance and is used elsewhere for visionary likenesses, and the command to have dominion ('radah') is joined to the image clause as a following purpose rather than as its definition. Because the words name a representation without spelling out its inner content, the text leaves honest room for three readings: the image as a created endowment of human nature, the image as a capacity for relationship, and the image as a royal calling to represent God by ruling. Each fits the words. The vocabulary affirms the image clearly but does not rank these accounts of its content.

Word dictionary

Every Hebrew and Greek word this study leans on, in everyday terms. Shaded rows are the anchor words the verdict rests on.

Strong	Word	Sounds like	Plain meaning	Times in Bible
H0120	אָדָם	adam	man	482
H0430	אֱלֹהִים	elohim	God	
H0582	אָנוּשׁ	enosh	human	
H1121	בֶּן	ben	son	
H1254	בָּרָא	bara	to create	46

H1818	דם	dam	blood	341
H1823	דמות	demuth	likeness	24
H1926	הדר	hadar	glory	
H2145	זכר	zakar	male	80
H3519	כבוד	kavod	glory	
H5347	נקבה	neqebah	female	22
H6213	עשה	asah	to make	
H6754	צלם	tselem	image	16
H7287	רדה	radah	to rule	18
G0341	ἀνακαινός	anakainoo	to renew	2
G0444	ἄνθρωπος	anthropos	a human	558
G1504	εἰκών	eikon	image	23
G1922	ἐπίγνωσις	epignosis	knowledge	20
G2316	θεός	theos	God	
G2672	καταράσμαι	kataaraomai	to curse	6
G2936	κτίζω	ktizo	to create	15
G3669	ὁμοίωσις	homoiosis	likeness	1

Plain meanings: STEP Bible brief lexicons TBESH (Hebrew) and TBESG (Greek), CC BY 4.0. Counts are occurrences across the 66-book canon.

Verdict rationale

Variant-robust: True · Pan-canonical: True

That humanity bears God's image is lexically decisive. The Hebrew words for image (tselem, Strong's H6754) and likeness (demuth, H1823) are predicated of humanity (adam, H0120) at creation in Genesis 1:26-27, with both nouns carrying the first-person-plural suffix (in our image, after our likeness, that is, the 'our' belongs to God). The same word image (tselem) grounds the murder prohibition in Genesis 9:6 through a 'because' clause (causal ki, the Hebrew word for 'because'), confirming the image persists after the fall and covers every human whose blood may be shed. Psalm 8 restates it in royal idiom and James 3:9 uses a perfect participle (a verb form marking a completed action whose result still stands, namely gegonotas, 'having been made') marking God's likeness (homoiosis) as an abiding condition of all people. The proposition is affirmed with high confidence. What the grammar leaves open is the CONTENT of the image, not its fact: image (tselem) most often denotes a physical representation or statue and likeness (demuth) a resemblance, and the coordinate command 'let them rule' (jussive radah, a Hebrew verb form expressing a wish or command, attached by a connecting 'and') is syntactically consequent to the image clause, not its definition, so substantive (the image is something humans ARE), relational (the image is how humans relate), and functional (the image is what humans DO as God's representatives) readings all fit the words.

Scripture

Gen.1.26 · for · genre: narrative

Key terms. H6754 צֶלֶם, H1823 דְמוּת, H0120 אָדָם, H7287A כְּדָה.

Reasoning. Divine deliberation in the form 'let us make humanity' (cohortative naaseh adam, a Hebrew form of self-encouragement, 'let us' plus the verb 'make' plus the noun 'humanity, adam) attaches two prepositional phrases to the creature being made: 'in our image' (be-tsalmenu, the noun image, tselem, with the 'our' ending, morphology code HR/Ncmisc/Sp1bp meaning Hebrew preposition plus common masculine singular construct noun plus first-person common plural pronoun suffix) and 'according to our likeness' (ki-dmutenu, the noun likeness, demuth, with the 'our' ending, morphology HR/Ncfsc/Sp1bp meaning Hebrew preposition plus common feminine singular construct noun plus first-person common plural pronoun suffix). Humanity (adam) is the referent of the image. The dominion verb 'rule' (radah) then appears as a coordinate 'and' plus a jussive (a Hebrew verb form expressing a wish or command, here 'and let them rule', we-yirdu, morphology HC/Vqu3mp meaning Hebrew connector plus simple-active jussive third-person masculine plural), a separate volitional clause consequent to the image, not an apposition (a renaming phrase) that defines it. This is the exact grammatical seam where the content of the image is left open: the words establish that humanity IS the image but do not internally state whether that image is a substance (something humans have or are made of), a relation (how humans relate), or the royal-representative function the following 'let them rule' clause expresses.

Gen.1.27 · for · genre: narrative

Key terms. H1254A בָּרָא, H6754 צֶלֶם, H2145 זָכָר, H5347 נְקֵבָה.

Reasoning. Triple use of the verb 'create' (bara) of 'the humanity' (ha-adam), twice with the phrase 'in the image of God' (be-tselem elohim), closing with 'male and female' (zakar uneqebah) and the plural object 'them' (otam). The image is predicated of humanity in both sexes, with no qualifier of age, ability, ethnicity, or stage. The plural 'them' (otam) forecloses any reading that confines the image to one representative individual. The poetic structuring (three parallel verb clauses) is real Hebrew parallelism but carries no figurative trope (no symbolic rhetorical device) from the closed enum (the fixed list of figure-of-speech categories the schema allows).

Gen.9.6 · for · genre: law

Key terms. H6754 צֶלֶם, H0120 אָדָם, H1818 דָם.

Reasoning. Post-flood (after the global flood narrative). The 'because' clause 'for in the image of God he made humanity' (causal ki be-tselem elohim asah et-ha-adam, where ki is Hebrew 'because', tselem is 'image', and adam is 'humanity') grounds the capital sanction against shedding human blood (dam). The causal 'because' (ki) ties the prohibition to an enduring image in post-fall humanity, demonstrating the image survives the fall and applies universally. This is the strongest single proof that the image is not forfeited by sin: it is the operative ground of a permanent legal protection.

Ps.8.5 · for · genre: wisdom

Key terms. H0120 אָדָם, H0582 אֲנוֹשׁ, H1121 בֶּן.

Reasoning. The words 'frail-mortal' (enosh) and 'son of humanity' (ben-adam, literally 'son of adam') together name humanity in its frailty. The rhetorical question (what is humanity that you remember it) sets up the dignity declaration of Psalm 8:6. The pairing of 'humanity' (adam) and 'frail-mortal' (enosh) broadens reference to humanity as a class. Notably Psalm 8 does NOT use 'image' (tselem) or 'likeness' (demuth), so it confirms the dignity theme without resolving the content question.

Ps.8.6 · for · genre: wisdom

Key terms. H3519 כְּבוֹד, H1926 קִדְרָה, H0430 אֱלֹהִים.

Reasoning. Humanity is crowned with 'glory' (kabod) and 'honor' (hadar) and made 'lacking little from God' (me-elohim, the preposition 'from' plus 'God'). The royal dignity vocabulary restates Genesis 1:26-27 in regal idiom and, with the dominion that follows in Psalm 8:7-9, lends weight to the functional royal-representative reading of the image, though it states dignity and rule rather than defining the image as such.

Jas.3.9 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G0444 ἄνθρωπος, G3669 ὁμοίωσις, G2672 καταράσθαι, G2316 θεός

Reasoning. The phrase 'those who have been made according to the likeness of God' (tous kath homoiosin theou gegonotas, where homoiosis is 'likeness' and gegonotas is the perfect participle 'having been made') modifies 'humans' (anthropous) as a perfect-participle predicate (a verb form marking completed action whose result still stands, attached as a description). The perfect 'having been made' (gegonotas) marks the likeness as a standing, completed-and-abiding condition of all humans, not a status forfeited by sin. James grounds an ethical prohibition (cursing fellow humans) on the universal likeness, the New Testament counterpart to Genesis 9:6. 'Likeness' (homoiosis) is a hapax (a word that occurs only once in the entire Bible) in the canon, so its precise sense cannot be triangulated from Greek usage and must be read off the Genesis 1:26 LXX (the Greek Old Testament, the Septuagint) background it echoes ('according to likeness', kath homoiosin).

Col.3.10 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G0341 ἀνακαινώνω, G1922 ἐπίγνωσις, G1504 εἰκών, G2936 κτίζω

Reasoning. The phrase 'the new (self) being renewed unto full knowledge according to the image of the one who created (it)' (ton neon ton anakainoumenon eis epignosin kat eikona tou ktisantos). The present passive participle 'being renewed' (anakainoumenon, an ongoing, in-progress description in passive voice) presupposes an original 'image' (eikon) now disfigured and being restored, and 'according to the image of the one who created' (kat eikona tou ktisantos) echoes Genesis 1:27 LXX (the Greek Old Testament, the Septuagint) which has 'according to the image of God' (kat eikona theou). The pairing with 'full knowledge' (epignosis) supplies one concrete New Testament filling of the image (a rational, knowing capacity being renewed), which tilts toward but does not exhaust the substantive reading (the view that the image is a created endowment in human nature).

Cross references invoked

From	To	Source	Votes
Gen.9.6	Gen.1.26	tsk	1
Jas.3.9	Gen.1.26	tsk	1
Col.3.10	Gen.1.26	tsk	1
Ps.8.6	Gen.1.26	tsk	1
Gen.1.26	Gen.5.1	tsk	1
Gen.1.26	Gen.9.2	tsk	1
Gen.1.27	Isa.43.7	tsk	1
Gen.9.6	Exod.21.12	tsk	1
Gen.1.26	Gen.3.22	tsk	1

Complicating texts

Gen.5.3 · addressed

Adam fathers Seth 'in his likeness, according to his image' (bi-dmuto ke-tsalmu, reusing the nouns likeness, demuth, and image, tselem). Some read this as transmitting the divine image only through procreation, but the syntax simply parallels Genesis 1:26 to mark Seth as fully human like his father. Since the same words for image (tselem) and likeness (demuth) are predicated of human-to-human resemblance, the verse confirms the image travels with humanity itself rather than being lost at the fall.

Gen.9.6 · addressed

This anchor is itself the resolution of a potential 'image-lost-at-the-fall' reading: post-fall it predicates 'image of God' (tselem elohim) of every human whose blood may be shed, so the causal 'because' (ki) shows the image persists and is universal.

1Cor.11.7 · addressed

Paul calls man 'image and glory of God' (eikon kai doxa theou) and woman 'glory of man' (doxa andros) in a contextual argument about head coverings. 'Image' (eikon) is the same word (Strong's G1504) used in Colossians 3:10, but here it is deployed in a relational, glory-displaying register for a specific church-order argument, not to deny the creational image to woman, which Genesis 1:27 explicitly extends to 'female' (neqebah). The general anthropological (humanity-wide) image of Genesis 1:26-27 and James 3:9 stands.

Ezek.1.26 · addressed

'Likeness' (demuth, Strong's H1823) dominates Ezekiel as visionary resemblance (the likeness of a throne, the likeness as the appearance of a man). This shows 'likeness' (demuth) means resemblance or comparison generally, not a defined theological substance, which is exactly why the content of the image in Genesis 1:26 is underdetermined (left unspecified) by the word itself. It does not contradict the proposition; it explains the lexical room for divergent content readings.

Concordance traversed

H6754, H1823, H1254A, H0120, H7287A, H2145, H5347, H1818, H6213A, G1504, G3669, G0341, G1922, G2936, G0444, G2672

Variants

Verdict variant-sensitive: False · ECM status: n/a

Old Testament anchors (Genesis 1:26-27, Genesis 9:6, Psalm 8) lie outside CBGM scope (the Coherence-Based Genealogical Method, a New Testament textual-criticism tool, does not cover Hebrew Old Testament texts). New Testament anchors (James 3:9, Colossians 3:10) lie outside the ingested ECM window (the ECM apparatus, the critical edition of New Testament textual variants, has only been ingested for 3 John 1:1 to 1:15 so far), so the 'not_in_ecm_scope' status holds. The known James 3:9 reading variation ('Lord', kurion, versus 'God', theon, for the object of blessing) does not touch the phrase 'those who have been made according to the likeness of God' (tous kath' homoiosin theou gegonotas), so the verdict is variant-robust on the image clause.

Hermeneutics

Primary method. grammatico-historical

Frameworks in play. substantive_image, relational_image, functional_royal_image

analogia scripturae invoked · progressive revelation factor

substantive_image: affirms · Reads the image as a created endowment of human nature (rationality, will, moral agency, capacity to know God). Strongest lexical support: Colossians 3:10 pairs the renewed 'image' (eikon) with 'full knowledge' (epignosis), and the use of 'image' (tselem) for a statue connotes a standing, structural likeness. The proposition (humans bear the image) holds; this lens specifies the image as a substance the words permit but do not compel.

relational_image: affirms · Reads the image as the capacity and calling for relationship, signaled by the plural divine deliberation (let US make) and the male-and-female pairing of Genesis 1:27, and by James 3:9 grounding how humans relate to one another. The proposition holds; this lens locates the image in relation rather than in an isolated faculty. The vocabulary neither confirms nor excludes it.

functional_royal_image: affirms · Reads the image as royal-representative office: humanity as God's vice-regent, supported by the coordinate 'let them rule' clause (jussive radah, a Hebrew command-form verb 'have dominion') immediately attached to the image clause, by 'image' (tselem) as the kind of representative statue a king set up, and by Psalm 8 crowning humanity with glory and rule. The proposition holds; this lens treats the dominion

mandate as the image's function. The grammar makes dominion consequent to (following from) the image, so this reading is strong but not forced.

All three lenses affirm the proposition that humanity bears God's image. They diverge only on the CONTENT of the image, which the anchor vocabulary underdetermines (does not fully specify). The lexical evidence does not rank them, so each is recorded as affirming on its strongest reading.

Stem audit

verdict-preloaded: no

The stem asserts that all humans bear God's image and lists dignity, moral agency, rationality, and relational capacity. The bare proposition (humans are made in God's image, universally) is lexically clean and not preloaded (not slanted by question wording). The enumerated capacities lean toward a substantive (something humans have or are) plus relational (capacity for relating) filling of the image, which the words of Genesis 1:26-27 do not themselves specify; this is captured under the competing-lens treatment rather than as a stem distortion, since the core claim is testable on its own terms and is affirmed.

Citations

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forms of image, tselem, and likeness, demuth, and the Greek readings of image, eikon, and likeness, homoiosis), so the aggregate is recorded honestly as not-safe-to-publish.

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